

Fatwa FACTORY

The latest religious edict from Deoband's Dar-ul-Uloom forbidding women from working in proximity to men creates a furore and highlights growing intolerance



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| By Farzand Ahmed |

It seems the Taliban of Afghanistan and North West Frontier Province of Pakistan have extended their dictatorial rule to India's Dar-ul-Uloom Deoband, the most prominent seminary of Islamic orthodoxy. Last week Darul Ifta, the edict-issuing faculty of the seminary, issued a fatwa that declared that it was un-Islamic for women to work with men and talk to them. The same edict under Shariah (Islamic laws) declared "haraam" (sinful) for the family to live off the earnings of such women. The fatwa, signed by Mufti Habibur Rahman, head of Darul Ifta, Mufti

Zainul Islam and Mufti Mahmood Bulandshahari—from the most powerful seminary after Cairo's Al Azhar—surprised and shocked many Muslim intellectuals and liberal clerics. Poet and lyricists Javed Akhtar told INDIA TODAY, "These fatwas are absurd. They are unrelated to the realities of life. Who listen to these mullahs?" He gave the example of a TV channel that showed a fatwa being issued for a few thousand rupees. "How can a fatwa that affects millions of Muslims be sold like this?" he asks.

In Lucknow, cleric Maulana Khalid Rasheed of Firangi Mahal (an Islamic seminary with Darul Ifta) said muftis (who can issue fatwas) should

WORKING MUSLIM WOMEN, EVEN THOSE IN BURQAS, ARE IN VIOLATION OF THE FATWA

issue edicts on important religious issues and examine who's asking for a fatwa and why. He says that clerics should understand that if a woman works within the limits of Shariah, she is showing that the community is progressing and that she is serving society and the country.

The fatwa asking Muslim women not to work with men or support their families through their earnings has wide ramifications. Bangalore's leading Urdu Daily *Siasat* showed a clear division among Muslims on the edict. "The fatwa says that women should